also this prison because we were all in there and, in a way, that's good and that's bad."

His departure and the US gave him a new lease of life, he found friends and lovers and finally a partner and home. But back in Mumbai, his father continued to battle alcoholism and his mother (a voracious reader and a beloved teacher) her own demons. The memoir is a tug of war between duty and selfhood, freedom and guilt. Suri wrote the book based on the 2,700 letters (which made it to The Limca Book of Records) that he exchanged with his parents.

The copious letters hint at the devotion between parents and son. Much of the book focuses on Suri's mother Prem who, from her marriage onwards, was forced to lower her expectations as she found that her husband did not share her inclination towards art, literature or politics.

Writing *A Room in Bombay* allowed Manil Suri to see his father anew. He had always perceived him through his mother's eyes as the dreamer and the drunk. But the book gave him new insights. Suri says, "My father's character was something that I learned the most about while writing this book and just sifting through the past and re-examining this person in the light of the larger story."

SURI WROTE THE BOOK BASED ON THE 2,700 LETTERS THAT HE EXCHANGED WITH HIS PARENTS. MUCH OF IT FOCUSES ON HIS MOTHER PREM

Suri—who was trained as a mathematician at Carnegie-Mellon University and has taught at University of Maryland Baltimore County (UMBC) since 1983—is accustomed to seeing patterns like a scientist. This training held him in good stead while navigating personal tumults. When dementia started robbing Prem of her senses, Suri had to find a solution that provided for her, while not upending his own life.

A Room in Bombay movingly illustrates the shapes of love and caregiving. It could be a wife who insists on cleaning her husband, even though she is loath to do it. It could be a son inviting his hallucinating mother into his home in another continent though he knows it will topple his life. It is a book about how liberation and guilt walk in tandem. As Suri says, "It's one thing to liberate yourself; if you're willing to snap off the major ties in your life with your parents, then you're home free. But you also have to keep tending to the ties that you're not willing to break and you shouldn't be breaking. So, it's a compromise. What do you optimise?"

A Room in Bombay reminds us that there are no optimal solutions; there is finally only compromise and love. ■

—Nandini Nair



NO AMOUNT OF **LOVINGLY DETAILED EXEGESIS** OF THIS FEUDAL LIFE CAN MASK ITS ESSENTIAL BRUTALITY

rather his characters, from upending the whole edifice. Because no amount of carefully, even lovingly, detailed exegesis of this feudal life can mask its essential brutality. "The world is governed more by chance than intention," observes Saqib, the main character in the last, longest eponymous section of *This is Where the Serpent Lives*, "as if a madman or a child were sovereign."

But the feudal world Mueenuddin itemises is inert. The one character who does transcend his circumstances is Bayazid, found on the street in Rawalpindi in the 1950s. Bayazid flees Rawalpindi because he is foolish enough to hope for love with a girl above his station, but winds up as the trusted driver to successive generations of Atar patriarchs.

Even Bayazid, though, goes only so far and appears content (except for a brief squall of protest at the very end of the novel) with how far he goes. Bayazid and Saqib bookend *This is Where the Servant Lives*, similar characters of different generations whose charisma, competence and ambition lead them in different directions. Readers will yearn for Saqib to triumph, for Pakistan to make the transition from the Atars to the Saqibs—but for that to happen, democracy would have had to succeed. And it's not a spoiler to say that democracy, a shared post-Independence dream in both Pakistan and India, is at best contained, at worst on the verge of being stamped out. ■

—Shougat Dasgupta